would spoil it, since AEB pilots were known to be finicky and strict. But I had grown up in a family that had always considered both their kids to be equals. If Dada was allowed to go out for late-night parties, I, too, was never questioned when I went for one, much to the disappointment of an overprotective Dada. So this whole experience inside the academy was new to me. Even if it was just an undercurrent, I could feel its existence.

Just one day before I was to fly the sortie with the AEB, the CFI called me to his office and asked me to fly two sorties with him to brush up on my flying skills. I wanted to request the CFI to allow me to fly these two practice sorties with Babs Sir, but I couldn't, of course. The two practice sorties were flown in the afternoon. The CFI made me revise aerobatic manoeuvres and check procedures.

The next day, I flew a sortie with Group Captain Damodaran. To my surprise, and to everyone else's, the sortie was considered to have been exceptionally well executed by the CO of AEB. There was no point given from the AEB's side after the sortie and they were all praise for the flying training branch. It was another feather in the cap of the CFI. A central briefing was organized after the AEB visit. The CFI explained what went well and what needed to be improved. Overall, the visit had been a success.

Towards the end of the briefing, the CFI mentioned that I had made the academy proud by flying one of the most perfect practice sorties with the CO of the AEB. Even the male cadets and instructors were happy and congratulated me after he had finished. For me, it was a step forward. I had been accepted among my male cadets and I was pleased with everything that had happened.

Indian military is one place that is free from any gender bias or discrimination. If I could spend the rest of my life in uniform serving in the armed forces, I would willingly do so.